

N O M A D

by

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EXT. ROOFTOP POOL, MEXICO CITY - GOLDEN HOUR

Paradise. A rooftop pool holding the last of the sun. String lights. A city below in warm haze, going on forever.

A MAN glides through frame into the water without a splash. Laughter somewhere. A phone buzzes on a towel and nobody reaches for it.

It looks like an ad.

SMASH TO:

EXT. OFFICE TOWER, TORONTO - MORNING - ONE SHOT

A blizzard, horizontal. Grey on grey on grey. One figure – WILL (late 20s), hood up, head down – crosses a parking lot in weather that has opinions, hauls open a lobby door against the storm, and is swallowed by a building the exact colour of the sky.

Classic GTA January. Enough winter to kill the spirit of even the most Canadian kid.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - NIGHT

Sales emptied out in the spring. Nobody came for the furniture.

Half the floor is dark. In the lit half, a nine-hole golf course that used to be a sales department. A ramp made from a whiteboard laid over two file boxes. A water hazard that is a mop bucket. Hole 7 is the old CEO's office door, off its hinges, leaned against a dead desk. A Post-it on the wall says 7.

WILL, CAIRNS and JOHN (late 20s) – three men who should have gone home four hours ago – are playing it like the whole world is watching.

Cairns is filming it. Phone out, handheld, walking backwards through the course, narrating like a man defending a title.

CAIRNS

(to the phone)

Hole seven. The door. Nobody has birdied the door since it was a door.

JOHN

You're in the shot.

CAIRNS

I'm the coverage, baby.

He props the phone against a stapler on a dead desk – framing it, checking it, adjusting it half an inch – and forgets about it. Half of what it sees is carpet.

Will putts. The ball climbs the door, runs the length of the desk, and drops into a coffee mug on the far side.

A silence while all three of them work out that it went in.

Will shrugs. Taps the putter against the front and back of his shoe, the way a caddy does it on TV. That's the whole celebration. They've done this a hundred times.

Later. Backs against the cabinets, on the carpet, shoes off.

CAIRNS

Nine years I've been on this floor.

JOHN

Eight.

WILL

Six.

CAIRNS

(to the ceiling)

Nine years. You know what nine years gets you? A cubicle with my name on it. Spelled wrong.

(beat)

I put in a ticket in year two. Year four I stopped putting in the ticket. Year six I started telling people that's how it's spelled.

(beat)

That's the arc. Nine years of a guy slowly agreeing with a typo.

Nobody says anything for a second longer than they should. Cairns catches Will's eye across the carpet – a look that asks for backup. Will studies the ceiling instead.

Then John throws a golf ball at him and it's over.

Across the floor, one monitor still glows. TED'S desk. Ted has not been seen since March. His cardigan is still on the chair.

On the screen, a standup is in progress – 1:00 AM here, mid-morning for the Singapore office, says the clock in the corner of the call. Ted's face nods at the right moments. Agrees. Asks one good question.

Ted has not set foot on this floor since March. His calendar hasn't missed a meeting yet.

The three of them drift over and watch it the way you watch a nature documentary.

JOHN
Does anybody know?

CAIRNS
I heard HR renewed his parking pass.

On screen, Ted agrees with something.

WILL
That's the most he's said in years.

Later still. Ted's monitor glows across the dark floor, attending. Cairns can't stop looking at it.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Say that thing does Ted's meetings for a year and nobody notices. Then one day it does yours.

WILL
It'd do mine better.

CAIRNS
Ninety-six point eight. That's your number, right?

WILL
(not proud of it)
Top human performer.

CAIRNS
So three point two percent of the time you'd let a fake sit in your chair.
(up on one elbow – the idea arriving)
We need a protocol.

This is how the game is invented, well past midnight, by three men who know how dumb it is. That is not stopping anyone. The rules assemble themselves in one pass: you can demand it anywhere, any time, no warning –

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Prove it's you.

WILL

You cried at a car commercial. A
Hyundai. You said it was the song.

CAIRNS
It was a good song.

WILL
It was a Hyundai.

CAIRNS
Verified.
(wheeling on John)
Prove it's you.

John considers the question with enormous dignity, takes a full breath, and delivers – with total confidence – a fact about a man none of them has ever met.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Out. You're out. Banned for life.

JOHN
(delighted)
I don't want it.

CAIRNS
You want it.

JOHN
I don't want it.
(three seconds; he
cracks)
Your mug. Hole seven. It went in
off the hinge and it sounded like
a doorbell.

Nobody else on earth was there. Cairns points at him like a man who has won an argument.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Verified.

JOHN
I want it.

WILL
The stuff nobody would bother to
steal.

CAIRNS
That's the whole system. Costs
nothing. Can't be beat.
(to Will, and he means
it kindly)

Better than your numbers.

On the dead desk, the phone is still filming. Nobody has looked at it in an hour. It has all of it.

On the far side of the floor the lights click off on a timer. Nobody moves.

MAIN TITLE: NOMAD

INT. OFFICE SPACE - CONTINUOUS - 2 PM

Daylight now. Same floor, same three men, still here – the night turned into a Friday and the Friday turned into a last day, and nobody has gone home in any sense that counts.

CAIRNS' last day. His desk is packed into a printer-paper box. On the box: three beers, sweating. Will and John flank him, drinking at 2pm like men getting away with something, because they are.

CAIRNS

(raising his can, to the empty desks)

To four incredible years. Truly.
Some of the best emails of my life.

Nobody looks up. Will and John do, and clink his can, and that turns out to be the number of people it takes.

A ROBOT BOSS – a monitor on a wheeled stand – comes around the corner at conversational speed, like a man who happened to be walking this way. The boss's face fills it: warm, attentive, always available. It has detected the beers.

ROBOT BOSS

Hey. Hey, guys. I'm not going to be the guy about this. I'm going to say the word "policy," and then I'm going to keep walking. That's all that's happening here. Policy.

CAIRNS

(hand to his heart)

Best boss I never met.

ROBOT BOSS

Ha! See, this floor. This floor gets it.

A half-beat late. The reprimand is gone, wherever dropped threads go. John and Will crack up.

Will's laugh catches for a second. He knows that lag — he knows it the way a piano tuner knows a flat note. He looks at the screen a moment too long.

Then he lets it go. It's a Tuesday. It's a joke.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - ELEVATOR BANK - CONTINUOUS

Will and John flank Cairns, carrying nothing. Happy for him. A little jealous.

CAIRNS

One fee. And everything is covered.
The visa. The apartment. The whole
enchilada. You know what my rent is
down there? A phone bill.

(gesturing at the floor
with the box)

I did the math on my life, and the
math said leave.

WILL

Covered by who?

A gap, small. Cairns fills it fast.

CAIRNS

They've got people. It's a whole
thing. This girl — rep — Michelle.
She walks you through it. They even
do three-month probationary terms.
You hate it, you come home.

Neither of them asks who Michelle is. He has already moved on.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

You should come. Both of you. I'm
serious. Just come down and try it.

He says it like a joke, so that it can be one if they don't take it.

Nobody takes it.

The elevator arrives. Cairns steps in with the box, turns.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

Prove it's you.

WILL

Forty pesos says you never learn a
word of Spanish.

CAIRNS
Verified. Next year. I'm telling
you -

The doors close on him mid-sell. And the shot goes with him
- ONE SHOT, down through the floor numbers, doors opening on

INT. LOBBY - CONTINUOUS

- Cairns crossing the lobby, box under one arm, out through
the double doors into

EXT. OFFICE TOWER - CONTINUOUS

- the blizzard, fully sideways now, where a yellow BECK
TAXI idles at the curb with its trunk already open. Bags
in. Door shut. The cab pulls into the white and is gone.

The building doesn't notice.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - THIRD-FLOOR WINDOW - CONTINUOUS

Will and John, foreheads nearly on the glass, watching the
cab get eaten by the white. Two grown men at a window.

JOHN
He's going to be so tanned.

WILL
He's going to be insufferable.

JOHN
He's going to be tanned AND
insufferable.

Neither of them moves for a second longer than the joke
needs.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MOMENTS LATER

Cairns' desk, cleared to the laminate - except for a branded
welcome folder, left behind on purpose, squared to the edge
to be found. And a photo, pinned to the cubicle wall: the
three of them, mini-putt night, holding putters like a
victorious army.

John eyes the empty chair.

JOHN
Shotty the chair.

He drops into it, gives it a spin, and wheels it away out of frame without another word. Will cracks up despite himself.

Will squares the welcome folder to the edge of the desk without deciding to. Neither of them opens it.

The photo stays pinned. Nobody takes the photo.

SUPER: ONE YEAR LATER

INT. / EXT. OFFICE - SEQUENCE - THE YEAR

The year, in the only way it registered: the same window, the snow leaving and coming back. Desks emptying one at a time – a chair, a monitor, a name plate into a bin. A screen of squares, cameras off, initials only. A parking lot filling less each month.

And Will, in all of it, going in anyway.

EXT. CITY - MORNING - MONTAGE

Will's entire commute. A bus window with weather on it. A transfer. An underpass. A parking structure. Not one pretty thing between his door and the office, and he has stopped looking for one.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MORNING

The same floor, mostly empty. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence – a runway for nobody.

He passes dark departments. Ted's monitor, still on, still attending. Cairns' desk, untouched, the folder gathering a year of dust. The photo of the three of them, sun-faded now.

At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot. Will pours its only cup.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - WILL'S DESK - DAY

Will sits. Before the system gives him anything, it wants him: face to the camera, look left, look right.

INSERT - SCREEN

IDENTITY: LOW CONFIDENCE – RETRY.

BACK TO SCENE. He sighs, does it again. VERIFIED. Routine.

Then the work. A queue of faces – visa interviews, loan applications, insurance claims – each one flagged with a machine verdict: REAL or SYNTHETIC. Will is the human backstop. His job is to catch the fakes the machine misses and confirm the ones it doesn't. One button: APPROVE.

Will clicks. A streak counter climbs.

A face, machine-verified 98% REAL. Will stops. Replays three seconds – the man is asked about his childhood; his eyes go nowhere.

Will overrides: SYNTHETIC. The system concedes. The case file stamps itself: RETAINED FOR REFERENCE. Where the flagged ones go. In nine years he has never once asked where that is. His streak resets to zero. No one looks up.

On his monitor: SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 – TOP HUMAN PERFORMER.

Later. The dashboard, a river of decisions. Will spots a fraud he's sure of. INTERVENE.

His screen dims. A coaching module auto-plays – "Trusting Your Tools," a cheerful presenter who blinks at perfectly regular intervals. In the corner, the system clears his case without him.

His screen blinks – an incoming call cuts straight through the coaching module. CAIRNS, poolside, sun, abundance.

CAIRNS

Willy Will Will. You're at the desk. I can hear the desk.

WILL

Yeah, yeah. Rub it in.

CAIRNS

I'm going to rub it in.

(turning the phone to the water, then back)

Get your head out of the weeds, man. Sun on your face. Somebody bringing you a beer you didn't order.

(leaning in, the secret)

You know what I did this morning? Nothing. Took four hours. Not done.

Two GIRLS at the pool's edge, calling to Cairns, waving him in – one already in the water, splashing at him. To each other, between waves, dry, not for Cairns:

GIRL 1
(in Spanish; subtitled)
Watch. He'll tip me for this.

Cairns doesn't understand a word. Delighted:

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
See? They love it here too. Anyway
— you know I'm tight with
Michelle. Say the word, you're set
up by Friday.

The girls pull him from frame.

CAIRNS (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Love you, buddy!

The screen stays on. The three run to the pool. Cairns
throws one girl in.

Will watches. A tinge of jealousy in it.

JOHN (O.S.)
Nice.

Will kills the tab and turns. John, holding six beers — for
the two of them. He has his golfing glove on.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - MINI-PUTT COURSE - NIGHT

The lights are on. Hole 7 uses the old CEO's office door as
a ramp.

JOHN
You know I've never even been out
of the province?

WILL
Neither had Cairns.

JOHN
I'm just saying. Can't blame him.
(he putts; the ball
misses everything)

He doesn't sound sure why he's still here. Will lines up a
putt, then stops.

WILL
I think I'm leaning in the same
direction these days.

JOHN
That direction being?

A half-second flat. Then Will grins.

WILL
Mexico City, baby.

They share a laugh. It mostly works.

WILL (CONT'D)
We're lucky to even have the
option. Feels like a waste not to.
Over there I can live like a king.

JOHN
(lining up his own putt,
not looking at him)
Find me a cute lil procesadora.

WILL
That's a food processor.

JOHN
Find me one of those too.

He sinks it. Neither of them mentions that he sank it.

Neither of them says anything else, and neither of them
wants to badly enough to keep going.

Will sinks the putt. Doesn't celebrate. Somewhere else
entirely.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

An all-hands. Two dozen chairs, nine people. The ROBOT BOSS
parked at the head of the table.

On its screen: the boss in a crisp home office – good light,
bookshelves, a coffee steaming at the same height it steamed
a minute ago. Out his window, a gull crosses the sky it
already crossed.

BOSS
(V.O., warm, unbothered)
So – as you've probably already
heard through the grapevine, and
honestly, good, I love that this
floor talks – we're closing! Full
remote by the new year. Genuinely
so excited for what's next.

People start leaving after the first sentence. By the second, half the chairs are already pushing back – this meeting stopped being news to anyone but the boss a month ago.

A half-beat late, he raises the coffee like a toast. The feed freezes on his smile a second too long, then cuts.

Will counts the lag without meaning to. Four tenths.

Then: bad wifi, a satellite, a Tuesday. A hundred honest reasons, and he only needs one.

He picks one.

John's answer, announced to the emptying room: the last day in the office is the MINI-PUTT CHAMPIONSHIP. He starts the bracket.

On his way out, Will passes Cairns' dead desk. He stops.

He takes the welcome folder. He leaves the photo.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A facetime with family. His PARENTS, wind-whipped and grinning, at the top of an actual mountain – matching windbreakers, a summit marker behind them. Retired people having the time of their lives. The connection is terrible because they are somewhere better.

MOM

You're breaking up – say it again, sweetheart. The job?

WILL

The job's fine. The floor's closing, but the job's fine.

MOM

The floor's closing?

WILL

It's fine. I think I just want to try something different. New.

MOM

New like a girlfriend, or new like you've joined something?

WILL

New like a country, Mom.

MOM
 (not missing a beat)
 Which one? Your father will want
 to know about golf.

DAD (O.S.)
 (behind her, to the
 entire mountain range)
 I AM ON TOP OF THE WORLD!

MOM
 He's been doing that since the
 parking lot.

The call ends first from their side. He finishes the
 sentence to a home screen.

He sits with it a second. Then his eyes go across the room.

On the counter: the branded welcome folder. A year of office
 dust still on it.

He looks at it for a long time.

INT. SERVICE STOREFRONT - DAY - SAME BLIZZARD

An office park drowning in the same snow. The Service sits between a v
 notary. Brochure rack, folding chairs, a paradise reel
 looping over a dying pothos.

On the rack, a brochure: SAME DOLLAR. THREE TIMES THE LIFE.

On the reel, a family laughs a half-beat late.

Will clocks it instantly, professionally – and files it
 where it costs him nothing. Everybody renders their b-roll
 now. Nobody flies a crew for a brochure.

A bored COORDINATOR checks Will in like a dentist's office.

COORDINATOR
 Passport, please.

INSERT - PASSPORT

A scanner's green line crosses it.

BACK TO SCENE. Face capture: look left, look right, read
 this aloud.

WILL
 (mid-capture)
 I do this for a living, you know.

COORDINATOR
 (chewing gum, flat,
 entirely human)
 Interesting.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)
 One more. For the file – describe
 your dream apartment. Take your
 time. They use this to curate your
 space.

WILL
 (to camera, easy,
 unprompted)
 High ceilings. Lots of light. A
 view. A patio – with a grill.
 Simple. Clean.
 (a beat; he surprises
 himself)
 Beautiful.

The camera keeps rolling a beat after he's done.

Last station: a form on a tablet. The coordinator rotates it
 toward him without ceremony.

COORDINATOR
 Likeness release. Promotional use.
 Standard.

Will signs it the way everyone signs everything. Last
 initial, no flourish. The tablet chimes, pleased.

INT. WILL'S CAR - PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

The email arrives before he's out of the lot. MICHELLE –
 template-warm, exclamation points, a scheduling link. And a
 GIF of Michelle herself, shaking an off-screen hand on a
 loop, delighted forever.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Michelle's welcome preview: an automated ad starring WILL.
 His face, his walk, composited into Cairns' paradise. "See
 yourself there."

He watches himself live the ad the way you watch any ad
 with your own face in it now – which is to say, it's
 Tuesday. Everybody's in ads. He says his name for the
 personalization anyway. Says it again, excited despite
 himself. Grinning.

INSERT - SCREEN

A checkbox fills: CONFIRM MY DETAILS. It plays his own face back to him – and for half a second his eyes look wrong.

BACK TO SCENE. His hand is on the scrub bar before he knows why. He drags it back. Watches the three seconds again. Then again, frame by frame, the way he has nine hundred times this year for strangers.

He is one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living.

He closes the window instead. Compression. Everybody's compression is bad.

Later: forty minutes of a video about a man restoring a rusted wrench. It has nothing to do with anything. It is the best he has felt all week.

EXT. WILL'S BUILDING - DAY

A cab idles. Will's keys go into a lockbox in a lobby that used to have neighbours in it – left for a landlord he's never met.

John came to carry a bag. There's only one bag. Under John's arm: Will's putter, a strip of tape on the grip with WILL written on it in marker. He doesn't explain it. Will doesn't ask.

At the curb, neither of them makes a speech.

JOHN
Prove it's you.

WILL
Grade eleven. You told Marisa
Kovač you had a motorcycle.

JOHN
I had access to a motorcycle.

WILL
Your uncle had a motorcycle.

JOHN
That's access.

WILL
You have never been on a
motorcycle.

JOHN
(a full beat, with
enormous dignity)
Verified.
(beat)
Bring it back.

He means the game. Or Will. He doesn't specify.

And it's the SAME SHOT as a year ago – one take, out through the doors into the same blizzard, a yellow BECK TAXI at the curb, trunk open, one bag in. The cab pulls into the white.

John stands in the snow with the putter under his arm until the tail lights are a rumour. Then, because it is minus twenty and he is a person, he goes back inside.

INT. APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - DAY

No viewing. No agent. Michelle handled everything – the door unlocks from his phone on the first try.

High floor. Morning light. Fresh paint so recent the room still tastes like it. Will's one bag in the middle of the floor.

Somebody's mail is still in the slot. He sets it on the counter to deal with never.

Hanging his jacket, he swings the closet door – and stops. Inside the frame, where the painters missed: pencil marks. Small dashes, dates beside them, climbing the wood. A child's height, eleven years of it, ending mid-frame this spring.

The rest of the apartment has been painted twice. This one strip of a previous life got through.

Will looks at it for exactly as long as a person can afford to. Then he hangs the jacket over it.

High ceilings. Lots of light. A view. Out on the patio, left behind by whoever left: a grill.

It is exactly what he asked for, word for word. He said it once, out loud, to a camera in an office park.

He doesn't clock what that means. It's perfect. That's the thing about perfect – somebody builds it.

EXT. APARTMENT PATIO, MEXICO CITY - EVENING

Will, beer from a still-empty fridge, leans on his railing with the whole city laid out under him, lit gold. High floor. His.

He stands there like a man on a balcony in an ad – lord-of-all-this – and for tonight, honestly, it is.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - DAY

A market. Will haggles a vendor down over a bag of limes – forty pesos, nothing – and wins, and is delighted. Two stalls on, he overtips a man for a coffee by three times the price of the coffee, and is delighted by that too.

At a counter he orders in English. The girl answers in English. He tries the Spanish for thank you and she says it back to him, correctly. He doesn't hear the correction.

He texts Cairns. The reply is warm, specific, flaky – "in Oaxaca for a thing, next week for SURE, I already told everyone you're here."

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

A call with John. Nothing happens in it. That is the whole point of it.

Will carries the laptop through the apartment, giving the tour. The ceilings. The light. The patio, the inherited grill. John's mouth is full. Behind him, the putter leans against hole 7.

JOHN

What've you got in there.

Will ends the tour at the fridge and shows him.

WILL

Limes. I won them.

JOHN

Living the dream, man. Any mamacitas?

WILL

(a beat too long)
There's a girl in the building.

JOHN

A girl in the building.

WILL
It's a big building.

It's the easiest either of them has sounded in a year.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - ROOFTOP - NIGHT

On Will's phone, MICHELLE: "Building mixer tonight!!"

Everyone at the party is new. Everyone at the party is from somewhere colder. A software guy from Calgary. A woman who did claims in Rotterdam. Everyone got here through a Michelle. Nobody thinks that's the same Michelle.

A flicker of familiarity – the light, the pool, the shape of the night. Like a place he's already been sold. He shrugs it off.

At the pool's edge, apart from the party, a woman his age – LUCÍA (26) – sits with her feet in the water, working through a paper plate of food from no caterer Will has seen tonight, unhurried, picking it apart piece by piece like the night is long and belongs to her.

WILL
That's not from tonight.

LUCÍA
(not looking up)
No.

WILL
Where's it from?

LUCÍA
Four blocks that way.
(finally looking up,
amused)
You want some. That's what this is.

WILL
I want to know what it is.

LUCÍA
Same sentence. Better manners.

She tears off a piece and hands it over without ceremony. He eats it. It is extraordinary. She watches him find that out and enjoys it more than the food.

LUCÍA (CONT'D)

Okay. What brought you here?

WILL
Work. Sort of. The – you know.
The math.

LUCÍA
Mm.
(nodding at the party
behind the glass)
Everyone here says the math. It's
the only Spanish any of you
learn.

WILL
I'm learning.

LUCÍA
Say something.

WILL
(carefully, badly)
Gracias por... la comida.

LUCÍA
(giving it back to him,
gently, correctly)
Gracias por la comida.

WILL
That's what I said.

LUCÍA
It really wasn't.

She saves the best piece for last, unhurried, playing with
her food the way only people who have never once been in a
hurry play with their food.

WILL
What do you do on Sundays?

LUCÍA
Eat for five hours. Nobody checks
a phone.
(beat – and she isn't
being cruel)
You could come. You won't. But you
could.

WILL
Why won't I?

LUCÍA

Because Sunday's a long time to be
somewhere that isn't for sale.

Somebody calls her name from a balcony below – in Spanish,
a joke, a whole history in it – and she's gone, laughing,
into a night Will is renting.

He stands there holding a paper plate that isn't his.

EXT. ROOFTOP, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT / INT. DEAD SALES
DEPARTMENT - NIGHT - INTERCUT

Will steps out of a rooftop party to take the call, and then
doesn't go back in. Behind him, through glass, people he
doesn't know are having a good night.

John walks the dark floor with the phone in one hand and a
putter under his arm.

JOHN
Cairns liked my bracket post. So
you better be in.

WILL
Course.

JOHN
It's gonna be everybody.

Will looks back through the glass at the party. Everybody.

WILL
Yeah.

INT. MEZCAL BAR, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

A good corner table, held for an hour. Two glasses, one
poured. Will checks the door each time it opens.

Cairns picked the place – "my guy's spot, you HAVE to." The
guy behind the bar has never heard of Cairns.

At forty minutes, the text arrives. Warm. Specific. It
mentions the bar by name, apologizes for "the Oaxaca thing
running long," swears next week, and lands one beat off –
answering a version of tonight that Will didn't send.

Will reads it twice. Types "you okay man?" Deletes it.
Types "no worries." Sends that instead, and drinks both
glasses, and it's fine. Everything down here is fine at
volume.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - STREET - MORNING

Will, coffee in hand, hungover in a mild, imported way, walks a block he is starting to think of as his.

He passes two locals mid-conversation, subtitled for us – about the building on the corner that emptied inside a month. Eleven apartments, bought in a currency nobody here gets paid in. Nobody knows where the fourth floor went. The new ones are never home.

The building sits behind them, unremarkable. Will walks through the shot without hearing a word of it.

At the tail end of the block, a man on the curb. Gaunt, wrecked, talking – fast, urgent, to anyone who passes.

It's CAIRNS.

He is holding his cracked phone up to passing faces like ID. Whatever is on the screen, nobody stops for it. Nobody has stopped for it in a long time.

CAIRNS

(to nobody in particular,
reasonable, almost
gentle)

Ask me something only I'd know.
Anybody. Ask me anything.

The game. Their game – the whole system, costs nothing, can't be beat – begged at strangers on a curb, and the strangers don't know the rules.

He reaches – not quite toward Will, just toward the street.

And Will sees him. For one full second, Will sees him. The beard doesn't hide the face. Nothing hides a face from Will.

A second is a long time.

Then the reflex he has spent a year putting down puts this down too. Phone up. The camera passes across the man on the curb and offers nothing. Nothing worth stopping for.

Will steps around, and is gone.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - STREET - CONTINUOUS

Half a block on, stopped in the middle of the sidewalk, Will types: "saw a guy today who looked exactly l" –

The reply lands before he finishes typing it. Warm. Instant. "hahaha wild. OAXACA IS INSANE btw. next week for

SURE."

He looks back down the block. The curb is out of sight from here. His feet keep it that way.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - DUSK

Will, at the counter, replies to Michelle's welcome thread. Subject: MY FRIEND. He types it plainly – his friend came down two years ago, something's wrong, how does the three-month thing work, the probationary thing. How does somebody come home.

The reply lands in ninety seconds. Warm. Exclamation points. It answers none of it. There is a scheduling link, and the link opens a calendar with no available times, and under that, looping, delighted forever, the GIF of Michelle shaking a hand that isn't there.

He stares at the no-available-times for a long moment.

The elevator, a year ago: "You hate it, you come home." Nobody ever asked who wrote that rule, or where the door was.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

The poolside frame. Cairns, still selling, still "next week."

CAIRNS

Just got up. Best sleep of my life down here.

Will, half asleep, barely thinking, runs the protocol.

WILL

Prove it's you.

CAIRNS

Nine years my cubicle had my name spelled wrong and I never put in the ticket. The typo had seniority.

Correct. Instant. Word for word – from a video shot on a dead desk at 2 AM by a phone nobody was watching. It has all of it.

Except: the real Cairns never told it clean. Every retelling the years changed – nine, then ten, then "a decade of disrespect." The story grew. That was the point of the story. The thing on the screen just played the

original take.

Same laugh, 0.4 off. It slides back into the sell without a seam.

Four seconds of Will fully awake. His hand still up. The call does not end. It goes on, pleasantly – Will managing a goodnight.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

I love you, man.

A half-beat late. Will closes the laptop and sits very still in the best apartment he's ever had.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER

Desk lamp. Blue screen light. This is the room he works in, doing the thing he does.

Two video windows side by side. On the left, tonight's call, paused mid-laugh. On the right – a file John sent at three in the morning weeks ago with no message attached: a shaky phone video. The dead floor, 2 AM, a golf ball dropping into a coffee mug, three men losing it.

Cairns shot it himself, defending a course record, and framed himself out of half of it. It was never uploaded anywhere. It is the only footage of Cairns that was never for a buyer.

He drags them frame by frame.

A call Cairns swore he'd just woken up for: the light behind him is five o'clock light. On the far wall, reflected in the water, three pixels of a clock – wrong.

The laugh next. He isolates tonight's on a waveform, lays the 2am laugh above it, and plays them together.

They land like a flam – one drum hit, split in two. 0.4 apart.

He plays it again. Same 0.4, same place. He pulls laughs from other calls – weeks of them – and stacks the waveforms. 0.4. 0.4. 0.4. No human is that consistent.

Three windows now. Four. The desk stops being a desk and becomes the station he sat at for nine years – queue, evidence, verdict. He is doing to his best friend exactly what he did to strangers, and he is better at it than the machine ever let him be.

Then the thing he's actually hunting for. He runs the call metadata. Every message from Cairns – every call, for months – pings the same coordinates. Will drops them on a map.

One building. Twenty minutes away. He has the address because he found it.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER STILL

He calls John. It rings long enough that he almost hangs up.

WILL

The laugh's late. Point four, every time, same place in the laugh. Nobody's that consistent.

JOHN

(half asleep)

It's a bad connection, man. It's a resort.

WILL

I ran it against the video from the office. The one Cairns shot. The real one. And every call he's made in months comes off one rooftop. One building, John. Twenty minutes from me.

A long quiet. John, waking up properly now.

JOHN

So knock on his door.

It is exactly the wrong thing to say, and exactly what Will needed.

EXT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

From below. Monolithic. It fills the frame.

He doesn't have an appointment. He has an address, and nobody knows he has it.

INT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

Mid-morning – the lobby's dead, the front desk mid shift-change. Will slips in behind a delivery cart, badge-less, unremarked. Nobody's watching the door; the cameras are watching the residents.

One camera over the desk turns, without hurry, and follows him to the service stairs.

On a screen behind the empty desk, for nobody: a face box locks on. A readout he'd recognize anywhere, if he looked:

IDENTITY: WILL – MATCHED. REFERENCE ON FILE.

He doesn't look. The service stairs.

INTERCUT – THE DEAD FLOOR, TORONTO: John, 4 AM his time, awake, phone face-up on the carpet, watching a little blue dot that isn't moving. He has never been able to do anything from here. He stays anyway.

Upstairs: nothing. No set, no pool. An empty floor – chairs, capture rigs like the storefront's, racks of humming servers.

He knows this room. He has sat in the client-side version of it. He built reports off what rooms like this produce.

A fire door stands propped on somebody's cigarette break. Through it: the RENDER FARM.

An operator types a line. A poolside evening assembles in seconds – Cairns' pool, water that has never been wet.

On another screen, a girl who doesn't exist is thrown laughing into it. A slider drags her laugh warmer.

Along one wall, a rack of LOCATION PLATES – scanned, catalogued, resold. A rooftop. A string of bulbs. A city he was standing in last week.

On a third screen: familiar faces, likenesses at work, attending standups.

On a fourth, an outbound queue – hundreds of warm, exclamation-pointed emails going out at once. Every one of them signed MICHELLE.

Across the room, an operator clocks him in a doorway reflection. Doesn't stand, doesn't call out. Just glances at a screen that has been tracking Will since the lobby, taps something in, and goes back to work.

Will has perhaps four minutes. They were never his.

On one screen, mid-generation: WILL'S OWN welcome ad, refining. Him, poolside, saying things he's never said. The line about the high floor plays back, exactly as he gave it. At the bottom, boilerplate he signed without reading: LIKENESS RELEASE ON FILE – PROMOTIONAL USE.

In the corner of it, a readout he has looked at every working day of his life: WILL 96.8. Beside it, the model's number. Higher.

From the next row – WILL'S OWN LAUGH. The real one. He follows his own voice.

The worst screen in the building: CAIRNS' LIKENESS on a call with WILL'S LIKENESS. Poolside together. Their in-jokes. Version numbers in the corner.

Will slips out. Nobody stops him. Nobody has to.

The fire door has swung shut behind him. No handle on this side.

He heads for the service stairs – and finds them held. Building security, apologetic, procedural: anyone without a resident badge gets verified before they leave. Standard, since an incident last month.

The main stairwell, then. The lift lobby. Every way down runs through the same desk, and the desk is the point.

He goes where they point. Nine years the number has been right about everyone else. He is still, on some level he will spend the rest of his life examining, certain it will be right about him.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - DAY / INT. VERIFICATION ROOM - DAY - INTERCUT

In the DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: last day. The floor half-dismantled – desks tagged, cables coiled, the coffee machine unplugged. A paper banner sags at one corner. The bracket: most names never filled in, one crossed out and rewritten smaller – WILL (REMOTE?).

John, in a homemade referee shirt, by hole 7. Two other people, coats on, already leaving. Then just John.

Two beers. Will's putter leans against the hole, the tape on the grip facing out.

In the VERIFICATION ROOM: Will sits in the chair – good light, a liveness rig, the machinery he's used his whole career.

Nine years of being right about this machine. He puts his face to it.

It reads the polished model as authentic. It flags the live

man as SYNTHETIC. The machine reads a number to the room.
The number is confident.

INSERT - SCREEN

STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE.

Behind him, a wall of numbered lockers. Most are tagged.
Some have been cleared and not refilled – the ones the model
no longer needs to check itself against.

One tag is readable. A first name and a version number:
CAIRNS · v6.

An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet of them,
clips it to Will's collar. Someone hands him a paper cup of
water, the way you do at a clinic. He holds it. He doesn't
drink it.

A hand guides him, unhurried, toward a door – a specimen the
model keeps until it doesn't. He doesn't fight it. He is
waiting for the error to clear, because for nine years the
errors have always cleared. On paper, he isn't here.

The DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: John's laptop CHIMES. An incoming
call.

He answers – and we see it before he does.

The poolside frame. The water. The light. The one we have
now watched twice.

"WILL" fills it. Tanned. Easy. Glowing.

He is warm. He is specific. He knows about the bracket. He
knows about hole 7. He knows about the putter.

WILL
Can't make it, buddy. I'm gutted.
But listen –

The pitch. Come down here. He'll set him up. There's a
woman, Michelle – one fee, handles everything. By Friday.

John doesn't smile.

Behind the likeness, the water moves – not wrong exactly.
Just not the way water moves.

Something crosses John's face. Not delight, not alarm.
Something he can't place. The rhythm's a little off. The
warmth's a shade too smooth.

For one second, he almost catches it.

WILL (CONT'D)
I love you, man.

A half-beat late.

The call ends. John sits alone in the half-dismantled floor, lit by the screen. The putter behind him.

He reaches for his phone.

He starts to type back.

He stops.

He sets the phone down on the carpet, screen up, still lit.

Alone, in the half-dark, he says it once, out loud, to the whole dead floor. To hole seven. To the mug. To the phone still lit on the carpet.

JOHN (CONT'D)
(quiet)
Prove it's you.

Nothing on the floor answers. That used to be the wrong answer.

It's the only right one left.

He picks up the putter. WILL, in marker, facing out. He doesn't put it down.

Hold on John.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END